London Borough of Camden
Information and Records Management
Judd Street
London.
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e-mail: foi@camden.gov.uk

Date: 14/02/2024
Ref: CAM6854

Dear Requester,

Thank you for your request for information dated 17/01/2024 about **the number of temporary accommodation properties, average length of stay and cost per night.** We have dealt with this under the Freedom of Information Act 2000.

Response

The council holds the information requested. However, we are withholding all of the information because it is exempt as explained below. We have explained where we are withholding information and what exemptions apply. Please see the refusal notices at the end of the questions which explain how and why they apply.

1. How many properties do you currently have on temporary accommodation in 2024? How many did you have in 2019? How many did you have in 2014? How many in 2010? How many in 2005? How many in 2000?

2. How many households do you have in hotels (- e.g. Travelodge, Premier Inn etc) in temporary accommodation, as of now, 2019 and 2014?

3. Please send a list, with as much information as you can provide with the names of the hotels you are using for temporary accommodation, including the rates you are paying per room and the length of stay of these families in this accommodation.

4. How many households are on the waiting list for permanent housing?

5. How many households are waiting to be moved into temporary accommodation?

6. How long do households stay, on average, in hotels, on a temporary accommodation basis?

7. How much are you currently paying in the hotels, per room, per night on average, to re-house a household?

8. How much does the nightly rate differ for single, double and triple bedrooms, in a hotel? (E.g., Travelodge, Premier Inn etc). For example, a family of four who would take 2 rooms in a hotel room - how much are you paying per night per room for them, on average?

9. What is the minimum and maximum you currently pay for a hotel room to relocate a household/family?

10. Please can you advise us on the MAXIMUM that your council CURRENTLY pays, per night for a: Studio, 1 Bed, 2 Bed, 3 Bed & 4 Bed in temporary accommodation nightly rate bookings. Please include the maximum rates for properties that you are currently paying, including that which is paid OVER your advertised rates. There is no way Pan-London/LHA rates are viable for any landlord so we would like to know how much you ACTUALLY are paying for your highly demanded temporary accommodation units.

11. Please can you advise us on the MAXIMUM that your council CURRENTLY pays per room for a HMO, on a nightly temporary accommodation basis? How do rates differ for self-contained units to shared amenity units? Please send a list of nightly rates. Please include the rates for properties that you are currently paying, including that which is paid over your advertised rates. There is no way Pan-London/LHA rates are viable for any landlord so we would like to know how much you ACTUALLY are paying for your highly demanded temporary accommodation units.

12. What is the average length of stay in HMO accommodation, on a temporary accommodation basis?

13. What is the MAXIMUM you CURRENTLY pay per night for hostels and Bed and Breakfasts for Studio, 1 Bed, 2 Bed, 3 Bed & 4 Bed property, in temporary accommodation? How does this differ for self-contained units? How much per room? Please include the rates for properties that you are currently paying, including that which is paid over your advertised rates. There is no way Pan-London rates are viable for any landlord so we would like to know how much you ACTUALLY are paying for your highly demanded temporary accommodation units.

14. What is the average length of stay in Hostels and Bed and breakfast accommodation, on a temporary accommodation basis?

15. Who are your largest 30 suppliers for temporary accommodation? Please send us a list and include hotels.

16. How many properties have they given you?

17. How much do you pay them, per year, for these properties?

18. If we were to supply nightly paid temporary accommodation on this basis, please can you give us all the available information you have for their: CONTACT NAMES, JOB DESCRIPTIONS and TELEPHONE NUMBERS (e.g. direct dials/extension numbers) of the procurement team(s) so we can get the ball rolling as soon as possible. This should include the email and phone numbers for the "head of housing," "head of temporary accommodation," "temporary accommodation team leader," "temporary accommodation officer" and "decant officer".

19. How many people and families are on the waiting list for temporary accommodation/decent housing in 2024? How many were on the waiting list for temporary housing in 2019?

20. What is the average length of stay for a temporary accommodation tenant, in a private-rented-sector unit. E.g., A house procurement from a private landlord by your Council? What is the average length of stay for a temporary accommodation tenant, in a hotel room?

21. How often, on average, are tenants moved from one temporary accommodation unit to another?

22. How many of your tenants are rehoused in each of the 32 London boroughs - on a temporary accommodation (and hostel) nightly paid basis? (If you do not have data for the 32, the top 10 is sufficient).

23. Does your council utilize decant (relocation) housing? If so, please can you give us all the available information you have for their: CONTACT NAMES, JOB DESCRIPTIONS and TELEPHONE NUMBERS (e.g. direct dials/extension numbers) of the procurement team(s) so we can get the ball rolling as soon as possible.

24. Please send me the department email and phone number for asylum seeker placements, outside of the home-office remit. For example, the re-housing for Ukrainian Families.

25. What is the max, min and average you are currently paying on for emergency decant housing, for different unit sizes, 1-6 bed property for example? E.g. Family of four emergency relocation into a four bedroom house, procuring a property from the Private rented sector, on a nightly let, emergency basis.

26. Please send a list of the top 10 housing associations you use to assist in Decanting your residents from one place to another, in temporary accommodation.

27. How much do you currently pay, on average, for a 3 bed temporary accommodation home on a nightly rate? How much do you currently pay for a 2 bed temporary accommodation unit on a nightly rate?

28. Does your council do "nightly rate block booking" for your temporary accommodation placement. This is temporary accommodation housing, which is paid on a nightly rate basis, that is block booked throughout a given period - e.g., 12 months - 5 years.

Refusal notice:

The exemption that applies is:

Section 12: Cost of Compliance Exceeds the Appropriate Limit

We are refusing your request under section 12 on cost grounds because we estimate that compliance with your request will exceed the "appropriate limit". This is £450 which is equivalent to 18 hours at £25 per hour. The per hour figure is set by Regulations rather than actual salary paid to any officers handling requests. The appropriate limit includes the time it will take the council to discover if it holds the information requested, to locate it, extract it and collate it as well as putting it into any particular format requested by the requester.

Once the council has ascertained that the appropriate limit will be reached it does not need to estimate the time that would be needed for the remainder of the request. There is no obligation on the council to work on a request until the 18 hours limit is reached, once it is reasonably calculated that the limit will be reached the entire request may be refused.

The information you are seeking for Q8, Q9 and Q11 is not readily available because the agreements for determining the rates applied to the procurement of temporary accommodation in London is complex.

The Local Housing Allowance (LHA) rate given for a household is the starting point for determining the cost of placing a household in temporary accommodation. The rates vary for each household according to the size and location of their temporary accommodation and is set nationally by the Valuation Office Agency (VOA). Camden is one of the boroughs that has committed to procure temporary accommodation at the Pan-London rates, in line with the Inter Borough Accommodation Agreement (IBAA) administered by the West London Alliance. The VOA divides London into a geography of Broad Rental Market Areas (BRMA), each having different rates for temporary accommodation that cuts across borough boundaries. The IBAA procurement agreement allows each borough to pay slightly different rates for properties in the same BRMA.

To calculate the maximum rate of each placement would require the creation of a data set for analysis by a council officer. It is estimated to extract and review the data for a single record would take approx. 5 minutes. To complete the task for all 700 households in temporary accommodation would take approx. 58 hours, this greatly exceeds the 18 hours required by the Act.

Advice and Assistance:

Given the calculations above, it would be difficult to refine the request so that it would take less than the time limit. We do have the answer to some questions and have provided this below by way of advice and assistance.

Regarding Q2, we hold some of the information. From 2019/20 onwards quarterly information on temporary accommodation is publicly available. You can view the data through the Department of Levelling Up, Housing and Communities link: https://www.gov.uk/government/statistical-data-sets/live-tables-on-homelessness. The data for all local authorities is provided in separate files for each quarter described as *'Detailed local authority level tables'*. Within each file, the sheet labelled *TA1* has a breakdown of the number of households by temporary accommodation type and also includes the number of children.

As the information requested is already reasonably accessible elsewhere it is exempt under the absolute exemption in Section 21

In response to Q4 on 31 January 2023, there were 7,035 households waiting to be housed by the London Borough of Camden.

For Q5 and Q19, we do not hold or maintain a waiting list for temporary accommodation.

Regarding Q23 and Q24, Camden does not use decant housing

Further Information:

We do not give our consent for any names and contact details provided in this response to be sent marketing material. Any such use will be reported to the ICO as a breach of General Data Protection Regulations and the Privacy and Electronic Communication Regulations.

Why not check our Portal Open Data Camden before making a new request as your question may already be answered by a previous FOI response or in one of our many useful and interesting datasets.

Your Rights

If you are not happy with how your response was handled you can request an Internal Review within 2 months of this letter by email to foireviews@camden.gov.uk or post: Information and Records Management Team, London Borough of Camden, Town Hall, Judd Street, London WC1H 9JE. Please quote your case reference number. If you are not satisfied with the Internal Review outcome you can complain to the Information Commissioner's Office at casework@ico.org.uk telephone 0303 123 1113, live chat https://ico.org.uk/global/contact-us/live-chat/ or webform https://ico.org.uk/global/contact-us/. The ICO website www.ico.org.uk may be useful.

Yours sincerely,

Lorna Jonas-Tinson
Information Rights Officer